

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

On weaning the women's vote crucial in Nitish's 2020 win: Well, last time, the vote per cent difference between both sides was less than one. This time, we have had extensive dialogues with women, and at the grassroots level. In all our interactions, their unhappiness with the government was clear, be it individually or in groups like Jeevika/Anganwadi workers or CM Didis. It's after these talks that we devised our sops, including interest waivers.

On allaying fears of the 'jungle raj': Look at the situation today. There's not a day when a rape case is not reported in Bihar. If you go through NCRB data, the top two crime-ridden states are UP and Bihar. So, the situation is the same even today. In fact, crime has been on the rise since 2005.... If we want to bring industry to Bihar, we'll have to work hard on two things: improving law and order and our energy requirements. I have been made the CM face, so I want to tell the people of Bihar that if even the shadow of Tejashwi does any wrong, action will be taken. People know me, my nature, my character, Tejashwi will never compromise on this at any cost.

On unemployment, migration, whether he'll announce dole for the unemployed: You have to be absolutely clear about the process of providing jobs. We started in those 17 months (when Tejashwi was deputy CM, from August 2022 to January 2024). Before that, even vacant posts were not being filled. We created and cut many posts, recruited teachers through the Bihar PSC. Nothing has happened in the interim.

"IN 2015, PM MODI HAD PROMISED TO MAKE BIHAR AN IT HUB. IT'S BEEN 10 YEARS. WHERE IS THE IT HUB? NOW SHAH'S TALKING OF AN AI HUB. YOU CAN'T TRUST THEM"

On announcing Mukesh Sahani as deputy CM candidate, the Muslim issue: Look, Sahani won't be the only deputy CM; in the future, members of other communities will also hold the post. In many places, there are five deputy CMs. In UP, the BJP has two, and both from their own party! At least, being an alliance, we have to consider the opinions of various parties. These BJP members were trolling us a few days ago, claiming the 18 per cent (Muslims) are not getting a deputy CM. When we announced an EBC as a deputy CM candidate, suddenly they are feeling uneasy. Earlier, they were telling them (the Muslims) to go to Pakistan, calling them infiltrators. Today, the BJP is also talking about them.

On the crucial EBC (extremely backward class) vote, PM Modi starting his campaign from late CM and socialist icon Karpoori Thakur's village in Samastipur: The BJP is anti-reservation. These same people used to hurl insults at Karpooriji when he first implemented reservations (in 1978) and brought down his government. Today, they have to bow before the power of numbers, the power of bahujans. After the 2023 caste survey, we increased the EBC quota to 27 per cent. The total SC, ST, OBC and EBC quota is now 65 per cent and total reservation (including EWS) is 75 per cent.

On Nitish as sushasan babu: The NDA has been in power for 20 years, yet Bihar is still the poorest state. Our per capita income is the lowest, unemployment the highest. Why is it so if they have worked so hard?

On the Bihar Adhikar Yatra and Vote Adhikar Yatra: Our questions were about the voter ID documents being demanded by the Election Commission. You are asking for documents people don't have...where will they get them and provide them in such a short time? We raised questions about the timing, how our people and the large number of Biharis settled outside the state will become voters. People who were alive were declared dead in the voter list, so we took those cases to the Supreme Court. At least now, our fight has yielded this verdict. The twelfth document will now be the Aadhaar card.

On what happens after November 14 (results day): After the 14th, the work of eradicating unemployment will begin in the state. The people will form a new government, for we want to see a new Bihar. ■